meet and snatch some moments together. Besides, it was much cooler in Tangdhar as compared to the hot summer in the plains of Punjab. When their holidays were about to finish, I took leave for a week and we travelled to Jalandhar. On the way we spent two days at Gulmarg with 2 Maratha LI being commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Har Ranjit Kalkat. We were welcomed very warmly and our stay with the Kali Panchwin (the Black Fifth, as this battalion is traditionally known) was memorable. In those days, Kashmir was peaceful and the people were friendly.

The tenure of the battalion got over by mid-1979 and we got orders to move to Poona. I was happy because we were going to a good peace station where we could be together once again. It had good schools where our children could study. I was approved to become a lieutenant colonel in 1980 and by then had become the second-in-command of the battalion. Normally, I should have been made the commanding officer of 7 Maratha LI itself, but the colonel of the regiment, Major General Bachittar Singh, was requested by all ranks of 9 Maratha LI that I must be reverted back to be their CO. It was conveyed to him that there were some problems in the unit, and it would be in the best interests of the battalion if I took over the command from Lieutenant Colonel A.F. Fernandes. So once again I had to move to an operational area, this time to Tezu, a remote place in Arunachal Pradesh.

Life had been tough for Rohini and the children, who were growing up in the absence of their father. From 1973 to '81, within a span of eight years, I had had eight postings alternating between peace and field.[3] One must admit that it was some 'yo-yoing'! There was great turbulence and insecurity in our family life which seriously affected the education of my children, Vivek and Urvashi. Things had got so bad that if ever they saw Rohini and me packing our bags for the weekend or a holiday, they would ask, 'Papa, are we transferred again?' This has been the true facet of life in the infantry. We are proud of the fact that we took all this in our stride. I never represented against any of these postings.